

Chasing the fireball

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Trine is a 2D platformer that is part of an emerging trend of the gaming industry to revisit its roots, and re-think the whole idea of 3D gameplay. Trine is based on a robust physics engine, that encourages players to think of creative ways to overcome obstacles using their surroundings.

There are three characters that the game starts with. Pontius, a Knight, Zoya, a thief, and Amadeus, a magician. The souls of these three heroes are combined into a single entity as the three reach out to grab an artifact at the beginning of the game. At this point, there is a charming exchange of words between, which only surfaces in the chapter transitions. From then on, the player can switch to any of the characters during the gameplay to use the abilities unique to these three heroes. The magician can conjure up boxes to overcome obstacles, the knight is for melee combat using a sword, and the thief uses a grapple hook to swing across chasms, and a bow for ranged combat. Later on into the game, the heroes get additional abilities, but these are too few and far between for the development angle to be engaging. The magician gets the ability to draw up planks and floating triangles. The thief can use multiple arrows, and arrows tipped with fire, and the knight eventually gets a very powerful hammer. Some levels require the player to light torches, which Zoya can achieve with fiery arrows, and Pontius with his blade. The Wizard is however, useless, as he does not know the fireball spell, which Zoya points out.

The levels are very detailed and beautiful, and the story follows a typical fantasy template of an evil power overcoming a kingdom. Traveling through the platformer, looking at the intricately detailed surroundings is a pleasure, a pleasure heavily marred by the seemingly endless number of skeletons that spawn and try to hamper your progress. What would have been a great tourist adventure has been turned into a cute little inappropriate nightmare. The combat soon becomes repetitive, and enduring the combat is a pain. There are a handful of new enemies that show up, spiders that spit venom and vampire bats that fly out and bite you when disturbed. The range of enemies is very limited, and relies on numbers rather than AI or creative use of weapons. There are a few boss monsters in between, but the novelty soon wears off. A frog with crystal amour on its back, and a giant skeleton, are the only boss monsters that you actually fight against. Sometimes, you kill a boss monster by dropping it into a void, and at other times you have no choice but to simply evade it. Later on in the game, the boss monsters are actually easier to kill

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than the regular supply of undead skeletons.

The most heavily underused aspect of the game is the very robust physics engine. Boxes, bricks, planks, pulleys, lifts and boards behave in a realistic manner. There are a few places where you have to creatively use a combination of these to get to a particular point. Say there is a swinging mace chained to a bar jutting out of the wall. You use the magician to levitate the mace in such a way that it is tied up to the bar, and cannot swing any more. Using the magician to create a crate, then impaling the crate on spikes in a wall, and using it as a ladder is a common approach. The puzzles themselves get repetitive, and not a single one is a challenge. You will not need to repetitively try to solve a puzzle, then look up for a walkthrough video on YouTube at any point of the game. The lack of a challenge, and the underuse of such a great game engine is very disappointing. The checkpoints in the game are automated, with no ability to save progress to a specific point. This often puts you back by a large distance, which makes you replay the same parts over and over again.

The only real challenge in the game comes up unintentionally. If any one of the three characters die, then you will be forced to play for a while with just the other characters. This will force you to use the abilities of the characters left alive in inventive ways. Players can choose to challenge themselves by trying to play the game with only two characters. The increased difficulty levels just add to the numbers of the undead hoard, and the abundance and strength of powerups. The game is very short, about six to eight hours of gameplay, but every minute of the game feels terribly long drawn out because of the force of numbers of the undead skeletons. At the end of the game, there is a typical tactic of introducing the element of time to escape, which makes sure you have to retry the level a couple of times.

The story wraps up in the end, with a short montage of how the three characters end up. In short, the game is great eye-candy, and a novel new platformer worth playing once but definitely not another Braid, Little Big Planet or World of Goo. The game is a little like Amadeus, a lot of cool tricks up his sleeve, but missing out on the elements that are most obviously necessary. **d**

RATINGS

Consoles.....PC, PS3, XBOX 360,
PublisherNobilis
DeveloperFrozenbyte
Rating.....5/10

